The Emancipation Proclamation & the Gettysburg Address

President Abraham Lincoln · January 1, 1863 & November 19, 1863

Source: Emancipation Proclamation (U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents) and Gettysburg Address, Bliss copy (Avalon Project, Yale Law School). Public domain.

The Emancipation Proclamation (Jan. 1, 1863) used Lincoln's war powers to declare enslaved people in Confederate-held territory 'forever free' and to authorize Black enlistment in the Union Army. The Gettysburg Address (Nov. 19, 1863), delivered at the dedication of the battlefield cemetery, reframed the war as a struggle to make the Declaration of Independence's promise of equality real. Read together, the two documents mark Lincoln's redefinition of the war's purpose.

Connect: The Gettysburg Address invokes 'all men are created equal.' How is Lincoln in 1863 using the Declaration (Class 3) to redefine what the war is about?

Key Passages

Emancipation — a war measure, with exceptions

by virtue of the power in me vested as Commander-in-Chief, of the Army and Navy of the United States in time of actual armed rebellion against the authority and government of the United States, and as a fit and necessary war measure for suppressing said rebellion … which excepted parts, are for the present, left precisely as if this proclamation were not issued.

Emancipation — freedom and Black enlistment

I do order and declare that all persons held as slaves within said designated States, and parts of States, are, and henceforward shall be free; and that the Executive government of the United States, including the military and naval authorities thereof, will recognize and maintain the freedom of said persons. … such persons of suitable condition, will be received into the armed service of the United States

Gettysburg Address — opening

Fourscore and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent a new nation, conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Gettysburg Address — closing

It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us … that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain, that this nation under God shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people shall not perish from the earth.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Civil War in its third year: Union victory at Antietam (1862) allowed the Proclamation; Gettysburg (July 1863) was the bloodiest battle of the war.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Proclamation: Confederate states, the Union army, enslaved people, and foreign powers such as Britain. Gettysburg: the crowd at the cemetery and the Northern public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Lincoln as commander in chief, using war powers and seeking to give meaning to the war; enslaved people's own role in seeking freedom is not described.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Specific Evidence (1 pt): Use TWO specific pieces of evidence from these documents to argue that the war's purpose changed between 1861 and 1863.
2. What did the Emancipation Proclamation NOT do — and why is that important?
3. How does the Gettysburg Address reframe the founding documents?